

The Laugh of Manik Sharma

In the wealthy city of Rajanpur, there lived a boy named **Manik Sharma**. He was born into one of the richest families in the region. His father owned textile factories, hotels, and acres of land. Their mansion stood like a palace above the city hills.

People envied the Sharma family.

But even as a child, Manik never understood why people called him fortunate.

When he was only six years old, tragedy entered his life like a silent storm.

One rainy night, his parents were returning from a business gathering when their car slipped from a mountain road. By morning, both of them were dead.

The mansion became empty.

Servants still cooked food. Business managers still bowed before him. Relatives still smiled around him.

But the warmth of love disappeared forever.

At night, young Manik would sit alone near the giant windows of the mansion, staring at the rain.

“Why did they leave me?” he used to whisper.

No one answered.

As years passed, Manik grew into a handsome and intelligent young man. He studied in elite schools and universities. People admired him everywhere he went.

But inside, he carried an invisible wound.

He feared attachment.

He feared losing people.

Still, at the age of twenty-one, he finally fell in love.

Her name was Anaya.

For the first time since childhood, Manik felt alive again. He believed destiny had finally shown kindness to him. They spent evenings together beside lakes, talking about dreams and the future.

Manik thought she would stay forever.

But forever ended quickly.

One afternoon, he discovered Anaya had left him for another man—a wealthy celebrity businessman from another city.

No explanation.

No apology.

Only absence.

That night Manik drank himself unconscious.

He stared at the ceiling and thought:

“People say love is pure. Then why does it disappear so easily?”

The wound inside him deepened.

At twenty-four, another disaster arrived.

Manik was driving alone through the highway late at night. Rain poured heavily across the road. His mind was clouded with memories and loneliness.

A truck suddenly appeared from the darkness.

The collision shattered the car into twisted metal.

For several moments, Manik believed he had died.

When he awoke in the hospital days later, half his body was injured. He could barely walk.

During recovery, he noticed something strange.

People who once surrounded him slowly disappeared.

Friends stopped visiting.

Business partners became distant.

Even relatives only cared about inheritance and company shares.

Again he asked himself:

“Is every relationship built only upon benefit?”

No answer came.

By the age of twenty-seven, the Sharma business empire began collapsing.

Corrupt executives stole money. Factories closed. Investors withdrew support. Newspapers mocked the downfall of the once-great Sharma family.

The world that respected him suddenly treated him as a failure.

One evening, Manik sat alone in the dark office of his father.

Dust covered the old furniture.

The city lights flickered outside the windows.

He looked at the balance sheets, legal documents, unpaid debts, and empty liquor bottles scattered around the room.

Then he laughed bitterly.

“All this struggle... for what?”

He began questioning everything.

Why do humans chase wealth if death takes it away?

Why do people love if separation is unavoidable?

Why are humans born only to suffer, age, and disappear?

What is success?

What is failure?

What are we truly?

Days became months.

Manik stopped attending social gatherings. He stopped caring about money. He wandered through streets, temples, and lonely parks asking questions nobody seemed able to answer.

Eventually, despair consumed him completely.

One cold night, he stood on the edge of a bridge above a dark river.

The city lights shimmered below like distant stars.

He thought:

“Perhaps life itself is meaningless.”

He closed his eyes.

And then—

A calm voice spoke behind him.

“Then who is the one calling it meaningless?”

Manik turned around.

An old monk stood silently beneath a streetlamp. His robes were simple. His face carried peace unlike anything Manik had ever seen.

The monk slowly approached him.

“Come,” he said gently. “Sit with me for a while before deciding to leave the world.”

They sat beneath a tree near the river until dawn.

For hours, Manik poured out every sorrow hidden inside him.

He spoke of his parents.

His loneliness.

His broken love.

His accident.

His collapsing empire.

His emptiness.

The monk listened without interruption.

Not once did he judge him.

Not once did he preach.

When Manik finally finished, exhausted and trembling, the monk smiled softly.

Then he asked:

“Tell me, Manik... everything you lost—was any of it truly yours?”

Manik remained silent.

The monk continued.

“You call them *my parents, my lover, my business, my life*. But before you were born, where were these things?”

Manik lowered his head.

The monk picked up a fallen leaf.

“This leaf falls because falling is its nature. Flowers bloom because blooming is their nature. Humans suffer because they try to hold what cannot be held.”

“But then,” Manik whispered, “what is the purpose of life?”

The monk smiled.

“To see.”

“To see what?”

“The truth.”

The monk pointed toward the flowing river.

“Everything changes. Everything passes. Pain comes and goes. Joy comes and goes. Wealth comes and goes. Even the person you call *yourself* changes every moment.”

“Then nothing matters?”

“No,” the monk replied gently. “It means everything is temporary... and therefore precious.”

Manik listened silently.

The monk continued:

“Suffering begins when humans demand permanence from an impermanent world.”

At that moment, something inside Manik cracked open.

For years he had fought reality itself.

He wanted people never to leave.

He wanted youth never to fade.

He wanted happiness never to end.

He wanted life to obey his desires.

And because of that, he suffered endlessly.

Suddenly, he understood.

The world was not cruel.

The world was simply changing.

Always changing.

Like waves.

Like wind.

Like seasons.

And for the first time in his life...

Manik laughed.

He laughed louder and louder beneath the dawn sky.

Not out of madness.

But out of freedom.

Years of sorrow dissolved into one clear realization:

Nothing was ever truly his to control.

The monk smiled peacefully.

“You have finally seen the first truth.”

From that day onward, Manik Sharma abandoned his remaining wealth and status.

He traveled with the monk through mountains, forests, villages, and temples. He studied silence, meditation, compassion, and the nature of the mind.

Years later, Manik himself became a monk.

But unlike many teachers, he did not speak with arrogance or mystery.

He spoke like a friend.

People gathered around him because his words carried the weight of real suffering.

He told grieving widows:
“Pain changes shape. Let it flow.”

He told angry men:
“You cannot calm fire with more fire.”

He told the wealthy:
“What you own today will one day own your mind.”

And he told the hopeless:
“The darkest moment often comes before understanding.”

Many people asked him:

“What was the greatest truth you discovered?”

Manik would smile softly and answer:

“Life was never against us. We were simply fighting against its nature.”

Then he would laugh quietly—the same laugh he first discovered beside the river under the dawn sky.